



RENTAL PROPERTY MANAGER

Installation Guide



Version 2.0 · July 2026

A private, local-first app for tracking rental income and expenses across all your properties — no subscription, no ads, no cloud account required.

Standalone

One person, one computer

Network

Shared team install

Free to Use

See LICENSE

*This guide covers installing and setting up the app. For a complete feature walkthrough once you're up and running, see the in-app **User Manual** (Help → User Manual).*

● Created by Beeran Rampersad

From download to your first property in six steps

1

Download the installer

Get **RentalManagerSetup.exe** from wherever it was shared with you.

2

Run it

No admin rights needed — it installs to your own user folder and adds a Start Menu entry (and optionally a desktop shortcut).

3

Launch Rental Property Manager

Your default browser opens automatically to the app — there's nothing separate to open.

4

Choose your mode

“**Just me on this computer**” for Standalone (nothing else to configure), or “**Shared server for a team**” for Network mode (have your PostgreSQL host, port, database name, username, and password ready).

5

Finish setup

Standalone: click **Finish Setup** — you're in. Network: test the database connection, create your first Admin account, then restart the app once when prompted.

6

Get started

Add your properties under **Properties**, then log transactions manually or import a bank statement under **Import**.

Need more detail on any of these steps, Network/Postgres setup, building your own installer, or troubleshooting? The full guide starts on the next page.

1. System Requirements

- **Packaged installer (recommended):** Windows 10 or 11. No Python installation needed — it's bundled inside the app.
- **Running from source:** Windows, macOS, or Linux with Python 3.9 or later.
- **Network mode only:** a reachable PostgreSQL 12+ database (can be on the same machine or elsewhere on your network).
- A modern web browser — the app opens in your system default browser and runs at `http://localhost:5000`.

2. Installing the Packaged App (Windows)

- Download **RentalManagerSetup.exe** and double-click it.
- It installs per-user (to `%LocalAppData%`) — no administrator rights required.
- You'll get a Start Menu entry, and can optionally add a desktop shortcut during install.
- An uninstaller is registered automatically (see Section 8).

Windows SmartScreen note: since this installer isn't distributed through the Microsoft Store, Windows may show a "Windows protected your PC" warning the first time you run it. Click **More info**, then **Run anyway**, if you trust the source it came from.

3. The First-Run Setup Wizard

Step 1 — Choose Mode

The very first time the app launches, it shows a one-time screen with two cards. **You can't switch modes later without a fresh install**, so pick the one that matches how you'll actually run this.

Just me on this computer	Shared server for a team
A private database on this machine only. No login screen — opens straight to the dashboard. Best for a single person managing their own properties.	Connects to a PostgreSQL database so a team can share the same data over your internal network. Adds a login screen with Admin / Editor / Viewer roles.

*Not sure? Choose "**Just me on this computer**" — it's the simpler option and covers most single-user cases.*

Standalone: Step 2

Click **Finish Setup**. That's it — the app opens straight to the dashboard, no login, no further configuration.

Network Mode: Steps 2–4

- **Connect to PostgreSQL:** enter the host, port (default 5432), database name, username, and password for the database your team will use. This database must already exist — the app creates its own tables inside it. Click **Test Connection & Continue**; the app verifies the connection before moving on.

- **Create the first Admin account:** username, optional email, and a password (8+ characters). This is the account you'll use to log in and add the rest of your team afterward from **Settings** → **Users**.
- **Restart required:** the app needs to restart once to connect using the new database instead of the one it started with. Close it completely and reopen it — you'll land on a login screen.

Setting up the PostgreSQL database itself (creating it, opening it up to your network, adding team members, and keeping the app running unattended as a service) is covered in full in **docs/deployment-guide.md** alongside the source code.

4. Running From Source (Developers)

If you'd rather run the app directly from the project folder instead of a packaged installer:

- **Windows:** double-click `run.bat` — it creates a virtual environment, installs dependencies, and starts the app.
- **Mac/Linux:** run `./run.sh` from a terminal.
- **Manual setup (any OS):** create a virtual environment, activate it, `pip install -r requirements.txt`, then `python launcher.py`.

This opens `http://localhost:5000` automatically and shows the same first-run setup screen described in Section 3. Your data lives in `data/rental_manager.db` — back this file up periodically.

5. Building Your Own Installer

If you're distributing this app to others rather than just running it yourself:

- Install Python 3.9+ (only needed for the build) and [Inno Setup](#) (free — version 6 or 7 both work).
- Run `build_exe.bat` — freezes the app into `dist\RentalManager\RentalManager.exe` with PyInstaller.
- Run `build_installer.bat` — compiles `installer.iss` into `installer_output\RentalManagerSetup.exe`, which also bundles the password-recovery scripts described in Section 7.

One installer covers both modes — which one a given install runs as is decided by the setup screen the person sees on first launch, not by which build you hand them. Nothing needs to be cleared out before building: your local test data is never bundled in.

6. Moving to a New Machine / Backups

- **Business Profile Only** (Settings → Backup & Restore) exports your name, address, contact info, colors, and logo — no properties or transactions. Good for quickly re-applying your branding to a fresh install.
- **Full Backup (Profile + Data)** exports everything. Importing a full backup **replaces all current data** in the install you import it into — meant for migrating machines or restoring after a problem, not merging two active installs.

7. If a Password Is Forgotten

- **Standalone (Access Password):** click **Forgot password?** on the lock screen and answer any one of your 3 security questions to set a new password. If you've also forgotten all 3 answers, the included `reset_access_password.py` script clears the password and questions directly from the database file, as a last resort.
- **Network mode:** any other Admin can reset a locked-out user's password in two clicks via **Settings** → **Users**. If every Admin is locked out at once, the included `reset_admin_password.py` script resets one directly against the PostgreSQL database.

8. Uninstalling

- Use **Start Menu** → **Rental Property Manager** → **Uninstall**, or Windows Settings → Apps → Rental Property Manager → Uninstall. No admin rights are needed since it was a per-user install.
- Your data folder is left in place so you don't lose anything by accident:
`%LocalAppData%\RentalManager\data`. Delete that folder manually afterward if you want a completely clean removal.

9. Troubleshooting

- **“Windows protected your PC” on first run:** see the SmartScreen note in Section 2.
- **Port 5000 already in use:** close any other program using that port, or check Task Manager for a previous copy of Rental Manager still running in the background.
- **“Inno Setup was not found” when building an installer:** install it from jrsoftware.org/isdl.php (Inno Setup 6 or 7), then re-run `build_installer.bat`.
- **Can't connect to PostgreSQL during Network mode setup:** confirm the database already exists, the host/port are reachable from this machine, and that PostgreSQL's `pg_hba.conf` allows connections from your network range — see `docs/deployment-guide.md`.

*This guide covers installation and setup only. For a complete walkthrough of every screen and feature once you're up and running, see the in-app **User Manual** (Help → User Manual) — it has both a Standalone and a Network edition.*